THE RETURN OF LALU

Jail, illness and the pandemic may have kept the septuagenarian RJD chief off the political stage, but he is back, energising his party's cadre as well as the national Opposition alliance

By Amitabh Srivastava

"Didn't learn to be afraid, didn't learn to bow out. Have fought, will fight, won't be afraid of jail, and will come out a winner in the end." These were the words that accompanied the Instagram reel that Bihar deputy chief minister Tejashwi Yadav posted of his father, the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav, playing badminton at the indoor court of the Patna Secretariat on July 28. Wearing a loose-fitting polo shirt, sweatpants and slippers, the 75-year-old politician looked pleased as he first served, then followed it up with a delicate return, in the video.

The message was unambiguous. That Lalu, who just about eight months ago went through a kidney transplant, is in fine fettle and ready to take on any challenge. Only a few days back, at the party's Foundation Day event in Patna on July 5, he had thrown one such challenge at Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "*Ukhad ke phenk denge, Narendra Modi ko* (we will uproot Narendra Modi)," the Bihar strongman had declared, before switching to chaste Bhojpuri—"*jahiya tu na rahi to te tohar ka hoi* (what will happen once you lose power)?"—triggering loud cheers from the RJD workers. It was Lalu's way of letting the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led Union government know that he is undeterred by the fresh land-for-job scam chargesheet that the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has filed against him, his wife Rabri Devi and son Tejashwi, his chosen heir.

Age and ill health may have taken a toll on him, but on that day, Lalu seemed to have rediscovered his trademark wit and extraordinary connect, something that many had found lacking when he last campaigned for the Bihar assembly bye-election in October 2021. As the former Bihar chief minister spoke, the whole gathering seemed energised. That video of him playing badminton could only come as a reassurance to his partymen that their septuagenarian leader is still very much in the game.

If Lalu is back in the thick of politics ever since he returned to Patna in April-end, after a successful kidney transplant in Singapore in December 2022, it could well be because he has much catching-up to do. The RJD boss missed campaigning in two key elections—the Lok Sabha one in 2019 and for the Bihar assembly in 2020—owing to medical complications as well as imprisonment in the fodder scam cases. Lalu was in jail from December 2017 to April 2021, before securing bail from the Jharkhand High Court. Though he addressed a couple of public meetings in October 2021, he appeared a shadow of his